



Strong bond: From early drills in Patna to bigger stages, Manish Ojha with Vaibhav Sooryavanshi — a journey still in motion. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

to enjoy everything. Whether it's 100 off 35 balls, 50 off 15, or a first-ball duck, you're allowed to score runs, and you're allowed to fail."

It helps that Sooryavanshi remains a kid at heart. Jitesh Sharma, who captained him in India A, had said, "He is very professional on the field, but off the field, he is (still a kid)... I'm trying my best, asking him not to eat ice cream at night. But he still has those cravings."

The A-B-C-D of Cricket

Back in Patna, Manish Ojha reflects on a journey that began in far more modest surroundings.

He still remembers the day in 2018, when Sooryavanshi came to Ojha's GenNex Academy in the city, holding his father Sanjeev's hand. The boy had just been gifted a Kashmiri willow on his birthday, and Sanjeev, a failed cricketer himself, wanted Ojha to work with his son.

That's how the narrative began to take shape.

"When Vaibhav came to me, he started from the A-B-C-D of cricket. So, the technical inputs or processes that he was taught, he never doubted," Ojha says. "He was a small kid and, for him, the belief system in his coach was immense. He must have been between 8-9 years old. So, the technical aspects that I gave him, he used to adopt very quickly," Ojha reminisces. Initially, Ojha would make Sooryavanshi repeat the same exercise all day.

"(When teaching Sooryavanshi how to play the front-foot drive) Around 70 per cent of the balls that day would be for him to go for the front-foot drive. I tried to maintain continuity. He used to try and execute it in the best way possible," he says. Later, the focus shifted entirely to strategy and planning.

"He was put in open-air match simulations. There used to be targets, like trying to find out how many runs he could make in 20 overs. Or how to protect his wicket in a 40-over game? How does one rotate strike then? How does one contribute to the team's overall total? According to such situations, we started giving him plans. And he used to play accordingly."

While Ojha takes pride in watching his ward scale new heights, he acknowledges there were certain "invisible flaws" in Sooryavanshi's game, ones the youngster worked through and refined.

"You will see that he bats very aggressively. And most aggressive batters use the bottom hand a lot," he says. "When you initiate any shot with the bottom hand, the downswing of the bat is a little dodgy. The flow of the bat deviates from the line slightly during shot-making. So, that is one thing that Vaibhav has improved. We have been marking him for a long time."

If Sooryavanshi eventually makes the Indian team, he will be the first cricketer from Bihar to don the national colours since the State was reinstated as a BCCI affiliate in 2018.

In the past, several cricketers from